

THE PRAYER OF JABEZ

TEXT: 1 Chronicles 4:9-10 (NKJV) *“Now Jabez was more honorable than his brothers, and his mother called his name Jabez, saying, “Because I bore him in pain.”¹⁰ And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, “Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!” So God granted him what he requested.”*

INTRO: The setting of our Scripture is a listing (or chronicle) of the genealogies of Israel approximately 3000 years ago. If you read the books of Chronicles it will not take you long to discover why it is called Chronicles. This book of 1 Chronicles traces the genealogies of the tribes of Israel from Adam to the death of David.

In this book there are literally hundreds of names most of which seem pretty insignificant, and most of which the majority of us cannot accurately pronounce. As a result, most of us who systematically read the Bible through dread the task of reading this portion of the Scripture. In fact, most of us only read it so that we can say that we read the Bible completely through. When I read the Bible through I feel somewhat of a relief when I have completed this portion of Scripture.

Of all the names mentioned in the first four chapters of this book, the writer stops and gives a little explanation of the life of one man, Jabez, and then in the very next verse the writer continues to ramble on with names we don't recognize or know how to pronounce.

You can take this Bible and study it from the Index to the maps and you will find absolutely zero information on this man named Jabez. In fact the only other place the name appears in the Word of God is two chapters earlier (2:55) and then it refers to the name of a village in which some scribes dwelt. It also

let's us know that the Kenites dwelt in Jabez. The Kenites were a tribe or nation of Canaan.

Jabez comes out of nowhere to appear in Holy Writ, prays one prayer of 33 words, receives an answer and then fades into oblivion.

This is a story of a difficult beginning: ***“his mother called his name Jabez, saying, because I bore him in pain.”*** The name Jabez comes from the Hebrew word yabets (yah-bates'), and literally means to grieve or be sorrowful. Johnny Cash used to sing about a boy named Sue, but here we have a boy named grief or sorrow. It would be like naming your child tragedy or funeral.

Many people have difficult beginnings; poverty; abuse; birth defects because of alcohol or drug abuse during pregnancy; physical handicaps; mental handicaps; dysfunctional families; etc...

This story of the life of Jabez starts out extremely bad; In Old Testament time's mothers named their children for something of significance in their lives. Look at this; this mother names her son Jabez: He will always be known as grief and sorrow. Every where he goes, everything he does, when his name is mentioned people will think of grief or sorrow.

We're not sure why this man's mother dealt him such a name; possibly she had an extremely difficult pregnancy; it could be that during her pregnancy some tragic event occurred within her family that would make both of their lives difficult; I could think of a thousand scenarios. The fact is we are not sure what happened, but we do know that she set her son up for failure. Many young lives have been set up for failure they have been told they are never going to amount to anything. When you do this you are cursing your children; ***“The power of life and death is in your tongue.”*** The power of life and death can also be in your actions and reactions. (My uncle; story of Keith and Debby Douglas)

It doesn't take a person with an I.Q. of 1246 to see that this child has been set up for failure. One thing in Jabez' favor is that anything he succeeds at will be a surprise to his mother and everyone else.

Somewhere, somehow Jabez discovered the power of prayer! I want to tell you, **PRAYER CHANGES THINGS**; if you don't believe me, ask a young man by the name of Jabez! Remember that 33 word prayer?

- It inducted Jabez into Israel's history books!
- It reveals a story of rags to riches!
- It reveals a story of personal triumph against all odds! 1 Chronicles 4:9 (NKJV) ***"And Jabez was more honorable than his brothers."***
- It changed the fortunes of Jabez; the young people would say it rocked his world! I say it rearranged his world! 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) ***"So God granted him what he requested."***

E. M. Bounds said ***"God shapes the world by prayer; prayers are death-less; they outlive the lives of those who utter them."***

With only two verses of exposure in the Scripture Jabez has been an inspiration to millions. He has removed every excuse for failure for the underprivileged. This is a dynamic story of a man who should have been cursed but received blessing. God wants to turn your tragedies into triumphs.

Tragedy is normally the fertile soil of miracles. Very few people will even consider personal change until they hit a dead end. This is true of sinners and saints alike!

Over the next few weeks we are going to allow Jabez to teach us how to be blessed.

I. A BELIEF SYSTEM ABOUT BLESSING!

A. There are two major obstacles in the path of blessing for most people:

- The belief system that say's I do not deserve to be blessed.
- The belief system that say's God does not want to bless me.

First of all I want us to look at the belief system that say's I do not deserve to be blessed:

I was raised in the church but I was never taught that God wanted us to be blessed. I can never remember hearing very many sermons on the blessings of the Lord, or the provision of God. I heard lots of preaching on the judgment of God.

I grew up with a belief system that said I did not deserve to be blessed. When I heard about the blessing of the Lord it seemed that it was something that was reserved for Bible characters and those who were holy enough to achieve sainthood!

Another problem that I had to overcome from my upbringing was the fact that we grew up in abject poverty, and nothing ever seemed to turn out right; success and blessing were very illusive objects you could never seem to get your hands around. It seemed that was just the way our life was destined to be.

As a result, when I did get blessed it came as a complete surprise and left me feeling that someone else must have got cheated. I reasoned that my blessing must have caused others to come up short.

Secondly I want us to look at the belief system that say's God does not want me to be blessed:

I also grew up with a belief system that said God was looking for a reason to punish me! I reasoned, if he was that determined to punish me he surely did not want to bless me.

I want to ask you a few questions to help you determine what you believe about being blessed and God's intentions toward you: (Answer the following questions on a number scale of 1 to 5. 1 being the weakest response possible 5 being the strongest response possible.)

I ask God for his blessing every day. _____

I can quickly recall specific blessings God has provided in the past. _____

I think of God as loving and eager to give me blessing. _____

I believe that one reason God hates sin in my life is because it blocks some of the blessings he wants to give me. _____

I've experienced that some of the greatest blessings in life grow out of my personal relationship with God. _____

YOUR TOTAL SCORE _____

21-25 you are flying high on the blessings of God.

16-20 you are a frequent flyer.

11-15 you are hoping to lift off soon.

5-10 you need to spread your wings for flying.

5-9 you don't need to miss one of these classes.

Jabez had every right to believe that he did not deserve to be blessed or that God did not want to bless him. After all, his own mother named him grief and sorrow. Jabez proved both of these belief systems wrong. In the face of all odds ***"Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, 'Oh, that You would bless me indeed'".***

In this scripture Jabez is crying out to God for supernatural intervention in the circumstances and destiny of his life.

For Jabez to do a thing like this he must first change a lifetime of wrong thinking. His entire life he has been told that all he will ever produce is grief and sorrow; that he does not deserve to be blessed; that it is not God's intention to bless him.

Jabez had no doubt spent his life watching others get blessed while his life continued to reel out of control and run in reverse.

As a child he watched the chariots pull away from the school yard with bumper stickers that read ***“My child is an honor student at Jerusalem elementary school”***, try as he did, he could never seem to make the grade. In junior high he went out for the ball team only to be overlooked by the coaches and their staff. As soon as he had a bride picked out someone better looking and more impressive showed up and stole the show. He went for job interviews and just when he landed an audience with the boss for his dream job someone with better credentials made application.

Jabez is a ***desperate*** man! ***Desperation*** is the fertile soil of miracles! Are you desperate for the blessing of the Lord?

If you desire the blessings of the Lord to run rampant in your life the first step is to believe:

You ***deserve*** to be blessed. None of us are worthy of the blessing of the Lord in and of ourselves. It is our sins that have caused us to become unworthy of His blessing. God created man in perfection; placed him in the garden; and walked with him in the cool of every evening. Sin disrupted the fellowship between God and man and thus restricted the flow of the blessing of the Lord. Man could not find a way back into the fellowship and blessing of the Lord. Isaiah 64:6 ***“But we are all like an unclean thing, and all our righteousnesses are like filthy rags; we all fade as a leaf, and our iniquities, like the wind have carried us away”*** Jesus died to make us worthy and to believe anything other than that is to minimize the power of His sinless Blood. Psalm 103:12 ***“As far as the east is from the west, So far has He removed our transgressions from us.”***

1 Peter 1:18-19 ***“Knowing that you were not redeemed with corruptible things, like silver or gold, from your aimless conduct received by tradition from your fathers,19 but with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot.”***

If you are saved by the Blood of Jesus you are as worthy as his Blood can make you and if you are as worthy as His Blood can make you then you deserve His blessings!

He wants to bless you! Genesis 1:27-31 ***“So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them.28 Then God blessed them, and God said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply; fill the earth and subdue it; have dominion over the fish of the sea, over the birds of the air, and over every living thing that moves on the earth.29 And God said, “See, I have given you every herb that yields seed which is on the face of all the earth, and every tree whose fruit yields seed; to you it shall be for food.30 “Also, to every beast of the earth, to every bird of the air, and to everything that creeps on the earth, in which there is life, I have given every green herb for food”; and it was so.31 Then God saw everything that He had made, and indeed it was very good. So the evening and the morning were the sixth day.”***

Deuteronomy 8:18 ***“And you shall remember the LORD your God, for it is He who gives you power to get wealth, that He may establish His covenant which He swore to your fathers, as it is this day.”***

Deuteronomy 11:13-15 ***“And it shall be that if you earnestly obey My commandments which I command you today, to love the LORD your God and serve Him with all your heart and with all your soul,14 then I will give you the rain for your land in its season, the early rain and the latter rain, that you may gather in your grain, your new wine, and your oil.15 And I will send grass in your fields for your livestock, that you may eat and be filled.”***

God blessed Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Rebecca, David, Job, Paul and others.

You may be saying I know God blessed the Israelites, and all the patriarchs but I'm not sure He wants to bless me. 2

Chronicles 16:9 ***“For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro***

throughout the whole earth, to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him.”

If God will bless a Jabez, and He did, He will no doubt bless you if you can believe Him to do so.

II. TWO KINDS OF BLESSINGS!

1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) *“And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.”* I think it almost goes without saying that all of us desire to have the blessing of the Lord upon everything we do. The problem is that most of us do not understand what the blessing of the Lord really looks like, or how to receive it. In order to understand what it looks like and how to receive it we must first understand what it is and is not.

A. BLESSING DEFINED - The word *“Bless”* means to favor, honor, or bestow special *gifts* or *status*. The Old Testament presses this word into service almost four hundred times.

In the Bible fathers pronounced blessings on their sons passing along the family birthright or blessing.

- Abraham blessed Isaac
- Isaac blessed Jacob & Esau
- David blessed Solomon

An earthly father pronouncing a blessing on his children is good and needful but what we are going to focus on tonight is our Heavenly Father’s favor or blessing upon us! The gifts we receive from him cannot be earned, and can be received from no other source.

The Bible clearly teaches God is concerned about all that we have need of; spiritually, physically; emotionally; relationally; and financially. John 10:10 (NKJV) *“The thief does not come*

except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.” The word “*Abundantly*” as it is used here comes from the Greek word “*Perissos*” (per-is-sos’) and means superior. Philippians 4:19 (NKJV) “*My God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.*”

I think we could safely conclude that it is the will of our Father to bestow favor, honor, special gifts and status upon us.

There are two kinds of blessings that I want us to explore tonight:

B. UNCONDITIONAL BLESSING – Unconditional blessings could also be called compassionate blessings. An unconditional blessing is a blessing based on the nature and character of God, He has simply decided to give the gift with no strings attached.

James 1:17-18 (NKJV) “*Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and comes down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning. 18 Of His own will He brought us forth by the word of truth, that we might be a kind of firstfruits of His creatures.*”

I want us to look at some examples of the unconditional blessing of the Lord:

- Abraham – Genesis 12:1-3 (NKJV) “*Now the LORD had said to Abram: Get out of your country, from your family and from your father’s house, to a land that I will show you. 2 I will make you a great nation; I will bless you and make your name great; and you shall be a blessing. 3 I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse him who curses you; and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.*”

- **Obed-Edom** - 2 Samuel 6:11 (NKJV) ***"The ark of the LORD remained in the house of Obed-Edom the Gittite three months. And the LORD blessed Obed-Edom and all his household."***
- **Salvation** - John 3:16 (NKJV) ***"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life."***

An unconditional blessing of the Lord is given with no additional requirements; for example;

GRACE + NOTHING = SALVATION

C. CONDITIONAL BLESSING - On God's part a conditional blessing is given from the same **free hearted** attitude as an unconditional blessing; He wants and intends for you to receive the blessing or benefit that He has so freely provided. Romans 8:28-31 (NKJV) ***"And we know that all things work together for good to those who love God, to those who are the called according to His purpose.²⁹ For whom He foreknew, He also predestined to be conformed to the image of His Son, that He might be the firstborn among many brethren.³⁰ Moreover whom He predestined, these He also called; whom He called, these He also justified; and whom He justified, these He also glorified. ³¹ What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who can be against us?"***

Ephesians 1:3-7 (NKJV) ***"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places in Christ,⁴ just as He chose us in Him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and without blame before Him in love,⁵ having predestined us to adoption as sons by Jesus Christ to Himself, according to the good pleasure of His will,⁶ to the praise of the glory of His grace, by which He has made us accepted in the Beloved.⁷ In Him we have redemption through His blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of His grace."***

(Explain predestination; free moral agency; plan of salvation; gifts and calling without repentance; Romans 11:29)

In the matter of a conditional blessing there are certain things you must do in order to activate the gift or blessing in your life. It's like owning a cell phone without having service!

Some examples of conditional blessings include:

- Baptism in the **Holy Spirit**; CONDITIONS – saved - yielded
- **Household** Salvation; CONDITIONS – pray - teach children right – set good example
- **Financial** blessings; CONDITIONS - pay tithes – be a good steward (When I pray for the people and their financial standing I pray for the ability to make good financial decisions; for proprietors I pray that they would keep expenses low and the income high, that their profitability will be greater than ever before.)

CONCLUSION: Jabez asked to be blessed, 1 Chronicles 4:10

“And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.” Do you think Jabez was requesting the conditional blessing or unconditional blessing of the Lord? Jabez like all of us knew full well that to achieve the level of success he had dreamed of he would need the conditional and unconditional blessing of the Lord!

SONG; “I am blessed”

III. MAKING THE MOST OF GOD’S BLESSING!

A. On the surface the prayer of Jabez seems to be a very **selfish** prayer, 1 Chronicles 4:10 ***“And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and***

***that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’
So God granted him what he requested.”***

How selfish can you be? Or is Jabez being selfish at all? I challenge you to look at it again... 1 Chronicles 4:10 ***“And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.”*** The blessings Jabez was praying for were not for his benefit alone, but for every other person connected to his life:

- ***“Keep me from evil”*** - If God grants Jabez this request he will not break the heart of his sweetheart... He will not abuse and batter his children... He will not rob a convenience store... He will not rape his neighbor’s daughter... He will not steal from his employer... etc...
- ***“That I may not cause pain”*** – If God grants Jabez his request he will win the citizen of the year award... He will receive the yard of the month award... He will be the parent of the year in the local PTA... He will be a model husband... He will be a wonderful father... He will be an awesome grandfather... He will be a faithful church member... He will pay his taxes and his tithes... He will not be responsible for putting gray hairs in his pastors head... etc...

God wants to bless you, but He wants to bless you in such a way that His blessing will positively impact everyone who is connected to you!

B. How should we pray? The disciples faced the same problem as we often do with regard to knowing how to pray. They asked Jesus, ***“Lord teach us to pray”***.

It is not always easy to know how to pray in various situations. We are told in Scripture that we are to pray in the following ways:

- To confess
- To repent
- To praise
- To worship
- To intercede for others
- To intercede for ourselves
- To pray for the blessing of the lord

I am convinced that the prayer of Jabez is a heart wrenching cry from a man destined for failure, to have his fortunes reversed. This cry was not nearly as much out of a desire to be comfortable and to have a pleasant life, as it was to make sure that he did not ruin the lives of those who were connected to him.

God wants you to pray to be blessed! Look at what the Word says about our relationship to God:

- 1 John 3:1 (NKJV) ***“Behold what manner of love the Father has bestowed on us, that we should be called children of God!”***
- Romans 8:16-17 (NKJV) ***“The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God,17 and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ...”***
- Matthew 7:7-11 (NKJV) ***“Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.8 For everyone who asks receives, and he who seeks finds, and to him who knocks it will be opened. Or what man is there among you who, if his son asks for bread, will give him a stone?10 Or if he asks for a fish, will he give him a serpent?11 If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”***

Please remember that the blessings of the Lord do not always translate into dollars and cents, fame or fortune. There is an erroneous teaching that says that if you do not drive a luxury automobile and live in a mansion you are not as spiritual as you should be. This teaching is not according to the Word of God. I do believe God wants us to have good things, but His primary reason for blessing us with things is so that we can be a conduit or channel of those things, ultimately using things to win others.

As God's children I believe He is pleased when we, like Jabez of old, ask for and receive the blessings he has in store for us.

C. So how do we strike a balance between asking to be blessed; maximizing that blessing; and making sure we are not just consuming the blessing of the Lord upon our own lusts?

- Seek first the kingdom of God - Matthew 6:33 (NKJV)
"But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things shall be added to you."
- Pray with pure motives – James 4:3 ***"You ask and do not receive, because you ask amiss, that you may spend it on your pleasures."***
- Pray according to God's will - 1 John 5:14 (NKJV)
"Now this is the confidence that we have in Him, that if we ask anything according to His will, He hears us."

IV. THE APPROPRIATION OF BLESSING!

Over the course of the past few weeks I think we have adequately proven that God... ..Wants to bless us! (We talked about whether or not we deserved to be blessed, and came to the conclusion that we are as worthy as the Blood of Jesus can make us)

...Has provided a way for us to be blessed! (We talked about two kinds of blessings; conditional, and unconditional)

...Helps us maximize the blessing of the Lord! (We are told to seek God first, pray with pure motives, and pray according to His will)

A. What should our attitude be when we come to God?

Hebrews 4:14-16 (NKJV) ***“Seeing then that we have a great High Priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast our confession.15 For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin.16 Let us therefore come boldly to the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need.”*** The word boldly as it is used here comes from the Greek word parrhesia (par-rhy-see-ah), and means to be outspoken, frank, blunt, and to do it publicly.

As I understand it, he is saying that we are to come before God with our requests in the same way a child would approach it's parents; telling it like it is; laying it all on the line; holding nothing back.

Going to the throne of grace should not be like going to the throne of judgment! Hold your head high, let your requests be known to God, He is your Father and His intention is to meet your need! He has the resources necessary and they are at your disposal!

Philippians 4:19 (NKJV) ***“And my God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.”*** God is so sure He is going to supply our needs that He put all of Heaven up as collateral against you and I getting our need supplied!

All God is looking for is someone who will come into the Throne room of Grace and boldly and confidently make a request for blessing!

B. We are to come to God by faith. James 1:5-8 (NKJV) ***“If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach, and it will be given to him.6 But let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for he who doubts is like a wave of the sea driven and tossed by the wind.7 For let not that man suppose that he will receive anything from the Lord;8 he is a double-minded man, unstable in all his ways.”***

Earthly parents are not dissimilar from God; we like to see confidence exuding from our children, and so does God! We like to see our children decide what they want and pursue it with a vengeance! (Story of Larissa selling Sam’s choice cokes) When you see this kind of confidence it puts you in the mood to do something behind the scene to make it happen, does it not? In the same way God delights in us! How do you think faith makes God feel when dealing with our requests for help?

C. We are told to ask, seek, and knock. Matthew 7:7 (NKJV) ***“Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.”*** I want us to briefly examine three things about this Scripture:

- Ask – This simply means to verbalize a request... The power of life and death is in the tongue... You have not because you ask not.
- Seek – This mean to go beyond asking to worship God. (God inhabits the praises of His people – He also inhabits the people of His praises)
- Knock – This means to anoint, as in smearing on. (Insect repellent)

Notice the result of verbalizing our requests, worshipping, and allowing His anointing to touch our lives; Matthew 7:8-11 (NKJV) ***“For everyone who asks receives, and he who seeks finds, and to him who knocks it will be opened.⁹ Or what man is there among you who, if his son asks for bread, will give him a stone?¹⁰ Or if he asks for a fish, will he give him a serpent?¹¹ If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”***

- **Receives** – This means to **lay hold** of an item; to **seize** it! The person who is bold in making his requests known to God will seize his blessing in life!
- **Finds** – This means to **obtain**. If you are a worshipper you will obtain the blessing of the Lord!
- **Opened** – This literally means to **open** up. You can starve to death with a can of chicken noodle soup in your pocket! When you get anointed things will begin to open up to you; knowledge of the Word Of God; opportunities for ministry; opportunities in business; opportunities to get blessed! It’s a Holy set-up! The opportunities that you have enjoyed would likely have passed you by, outside the anointing of the holy Spirit! Following the miracle of the loaves and fishes another miracle occurs that is oftentimes overlooked. Mark 6:46-51 (NKJV) ***“And when He had sent them away, He departed to the mountain to pray.⁴⁷ Now when evening came, the boat was in the middle of the sea; and He was alone on the land.⁴⁸ Then He saw them straining at rowing, for the wind was against them. Now about the fourth watch of the night He came to them, walking on the sea, and would have passed them by.⁴⁹ And when they saw Him walking on the sea, they supposed it was a ghost, and cried out;⁵⁰ for they all saw Him and were troubled. But immediately He talked with them and said to them, ‘**Be of good cheer! It is I; do not be afraid.**’⁵¹ Then He went up into the***

boat to them, and the wind ceased. And they were greatly amazed in themselves beyond measure, and marveled.” The only places Our heavenly Father goes are to those places he is invited to. He does not show up as a result of an invitation that is given under duress!

CONCLUSION: In our text I believe Jabez was exercising great faith by boldly entering in to the Throne Room of Grace. We know that Jabez verbalized his request before God, he said, 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) *“And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’”*

I believe Jabez was a worshipper of God. Otherwise why would he be so comfortable in making such a request? Worshipers are always comfortable asking for tough stuff! If you need someone to pray with you, find a worshipper! They have a direct line to heaven!

I believe Jabez was anointed; he certainly had an incentive to do so! Jabez lived with the realization that if God doesn’t help me and anoint me my life is going to be lived out being a pain, and being in pain! (Everyone either is a problem, has a problem, or knows a problem) If we do not lived anointed lives we all have the potential of living in pain and causing pain! (Hurting people, hurt people)

Look at the result of Jabez’ asking, seeking, and knocking, 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) *“So God granted him what he requested.”* Jabez seized, obtained, and opened his blessing! As a result he became more honorable than his brothers!

Are you going to be comfortable living a less than average life, or will you by faith approach the Throne room and walk away blessed?

V. THE RESTRICTION OF BLESSING!

A. Jabez began his life with a definite handicap. 1 Chronicles 4:9 (NKJV) “*Now Jabez was more honorable than his brothers, and his mother called his name Jabez, saying, ‘Because I bore him in pain’.*” Jabez’ handicap was not his own making; his mother was the responsible party. We are not told why she named her son such a thing but I assume something must have gone desperately wrong between the time she conceived him and the time she birthed him.

From the time of his birth Jabez was destined to fight an uphill battle in every area of his life; with childhood friends; with school mates; with girlfriends; with employment; with marriage; with success; etc...

People who are constantly fighting an uphill battle often develop an attitude problem. (Youth Pastor who thought he had to fight for everything he received)

An attitude problem usually produces the very thing the person is attempting to prevent. If an attitude problem is allowed to persist, it often develops behavior patterns. A behavior pattern forms habits that are often never admitted, confronted, or dealt with! When this occurs the handicap and all of its side effects drives the individuals’ life in a downward spiral.

Most people who knew Jabez, and were aware of why his mother named him such a self defeating name would have predicted disaster and destruction would follow him everywhere he went.

The sole reason Jabez’ life turned out opposite of all predictions and indicators is because he called on God, and God heard his prayer! Notice Jabez requested only four things:

- That you would bless me indeed...
- Enlarge my coasts...
- Your hand would be upon me...
- Don’t allow evil to affect me...

Jabez knew if he could receive these four things from the hand of the Lord he would never want for anything in life.

B. Most of us started life with some kind of a handicap. All of us probably received some things from the good old family gene pool that we view as a handicap; personality; temperament; looks; bone structure; weight problem; height; voice; habits; etc...

So you have a handicap... don't we all! So what are we going to do about it? Are we going to sit around and moan and groan over things we have no control over? Or, are we going to ask God to bless us and get up and make our life count one day at a time? The way to make it count is to live it one day at a time!

I think it is time for someone to get up and decide to make the devil pay the price every day, for attempting to handicap us! I believe that is exactly what Jabez decided. The blessings were not all realized in one day, they came about one at a time.

It is my opinion that God wants to help every one of us rise above the handicaps and predictions of our lives! If that is so, what would restrict Jabez, or us, from receiving the blessing of the Lord?

- Unworthiness... I don't believe I deserve the blessing of the Lord, therefore I don't expect it, thus I don't receive it...
- Fear... What if I can't handle it? What if I ask to be blessed and don't receive it? What if you do get blessed?
- Skepticism... I don't know if God is that concerned about the simple things in my little life... Martyr syndrome...

Let us look at what the Word says you should do when you feel;

- Restricted by feelings of unworthiness... Galatians 4:4-7 (NKJV) ***"But when the fullness of the time had come, God sent forth His Son, born of a woman, born***

under the law,⁵ to redeem those who were under the law, that we might receive the adoption as sons.⁶ And because you are sons, God has sent forth the Spirit of His Son into your hearts, crying out, 'Abba, Father'! ⁷ Therefore you are no longer a slave but a son, and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ.” Ephesians 2:8-10 (NKJV) “For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God,⁹ not of works, lest anyone should boast.¹⁰ For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand that we should walk in them.”

- Restricted by fear... 2 Timothy 1:7 (NKJV) “*For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.*”, Hebrews 13:5-6 (NKJV), “*Let your conduct be without covetousness; be content with such things as you have. For He Himself has said, ‘I will never leave you nor forsake you’.*” So we may boldly say: “*The LORD is my helper; I will not fear. What can man do to me?’*”, Romans 8:35-39 (NKJV) “*Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword?*³⁶ As it is written: ‘For Your sake we are killed all day long; We are accounted as sheep for the slaughter.’ ³⁷ Yet in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us.³⁸ For I am persuaded that neither death nor life, nor angels nor principalities nor powers, nor things present nor things to come,³⁹ nor height nor depth, nor any other created thing, shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.”
- Restricted by skepticism... Proverbs 3:5-6 (NKJV) “*Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; ⁶ In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall direct your paths.*”, Philippians 1:6 (NKJV) “*Being confident of this very*

thing, that He who has begun a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ;”, Hebrews 10:35-36 (NKJV) “Therefore do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward.36 For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise:”

CONCLUSION: Never forget: If a person like Jabez, who was living under the Old Covenant, can overcome all odds to press in and receive the blessing of the Lord, then surely you and I who live under a much better Covenant can overcome unworthiness, fear, and skepticism to receive from Him as well!

We should be as Jacob of old; lay hold of God and not let go until He blesses us!

VI. BENCHWARMERS OR BOUNDARY BUSTERS?

A. I believe you could categorize all people into one of two groups; people who watch things happen and people who make things happen; people who play it close to the vest and people who are always pushing the envelope; benchwarmers and boundary busters.

When you look at the life of Jabez one of the first things that will stand out to you is that he was not satisfied living his life the way someone else chose to define it. (People always attempt to define our lives: Parents – Employers – Coworkers – Spouses – Children – etc...)

Are you going to allow someone else to define your life? Tell you what you are capable of, and what you are not capable of? Set boundaries of success and demand that you not cross them? (Larissa – “Life is like a big drum, you just have to beat out your own rhythm!”)

When Jabez’ mother named him she set some boundaries for his life. She may not have meant to reduce his opportunities, but I believe she knew exactly what she was doing. Many times well

intentioned people reduce or restrict the opportunities available to you. When you connect yourself to certain people or organizations you either enhance the opportunity to fulfill your destiny, or you greatly restrict the opportunity to fulfill your destiny! In some cases you can make fulfilling your destiny impossible because of who you have decided to be identified with.

Samson was gifted and anointed to be God's answer for Israel in a critical hour; because of his choice of a mate he limited his potential to a blind skin head being led to his fate by a child. Samson traded the purposes of God for a few pleasurable moments with Delilah. Rather than being a chosen Nazarite he became a powerless spectacle of what might have been! Samson misused his mission and flunked out of purpose 101.

Esau sold his birthright to Jacob for a bowl of stew! The reference in the Scripture could have been Abraham, Isaac, and Esau; because Esau failed where Jabez succeeded the reference is Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

From among every person alive on planet earth Judas became one of only twelve to be chosen to be a disciple of Jesus Christ. He was privileged to see miracles unfolding first hand; lay his head on the bosom of an eternal God; be an eye witness of history in the making; yet, because of his desire to involve himself with religious politics he damaged his destiny beyond repair!

Sons go to the mountain with their father; servants camp out at an inferior height! Genesis 22:5-8 (KJV) ***“And Abraham said unto his young men, Abide ye here with the ass; and I and the lad will go yonder and worship, and come again to you. 6 And Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering, and laid it upon Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife; and they went both of them together. 7 And Isaac spake unto Abraham his father, and said, my father: and he said, here am I, my son. And he said behold the fire and the wood: but where is the lamb for a burnt offering? 8 And Abraham said,***

my son, God will provide himself a lamb for a burnt offering: so they went both of them together.”

I want to ask you are you connected to people who are keeping you back from your destiny? 2 Corinthians 6:14-18 NKJV ***“Do not be unequally yoked together with unbelievers. For what fellowship has righteousness with lawlessness? And what communion has light with darkness? 15 And what accord has Christ with Belial? Or what part has a believer with an unbeliever? 16 And what agreement has the temple of God with idols? For you are the temple of the living God. As God has said: ‘I will dwell in them and walk among them, I will be their God, and they shall be My people. 17 Therefore come out from among them and be separate”, says the Lord. ‘Do not touch what is unclean, and I will receive you. 18 I will be a Father to you, and you shall be My sons and daughters’, Says the LORD Almighty.”***

We want to use this Scripture when it is convenient for us; when our daughter wants to date some brainless freak of a kid who does not have enough sense to comb his hair, and pull his pants up to his waist.

But the Scripture is speaking also of unhealthy associations; this could even be someone who claims to be a Christian, but does not share your dreams. This could also be speaking of hanging out with a negative person! It could be talking of unhealthy business associates!

You will likely become who you are with! Who you are with will very likely become a determining factor in whether you become a benchwarmer or a boundary buster!

B. Jabez first prayed for blessing; his second request was for more territory. Of all the nerve, Mr. Pain asking to receive more territory! He should have been satisfied with just squeaking out a living; marrying an ugly girl with a hateful attitude; raising children who kept the sheriff busy; making obligations that

unnerved all of his creditors; but no, he had to pray for his territory to be enlarged!

In essence what Jabez is doing here is asking for a **larger life**. In asking for a larger life he is praying that everything about his life will turn out better than expected. (His family – his relationships - his holdings – his influence – etc...)

Jabez is beginning to appear as one of those people who cannot settle for status quo. We need to be delivered from the enemy of mediocrity. Mediocrity has neutered the church, and will do the same in every area of your life and influence.

Larger territory seems to be a good thing:

More authority...

More influence...

More things...

More responsibility...

Wait a minute, did someone say more responsibility? With a larger **territory** comes more **responsibility**!

Some people are willing to settle for a smaller territory if they can expect reduced responsibility. (Tribes of Reuben, Gad, and half the tribe of Manasseh)

Let me assure you that what you get with an enlarged territory will be worth the increased responsibility.

C. Enlarged territory can mean a host of things but it definitely has to do with being a part of God's overall **plan** in the **earth**. Some people struggle with whether or not they have a place in God's overall strategic plan for the ages.

Those who are not sure of where they fit into God's plan become benchwarmers that turn out to be under achievers. They may have started with high hopes but because of some momentary setbacks and too much bad company their life has been wasted and their destiny is no longer in sight.

Those who have invested the time and energy to discover God's destiny for their lives, know where they fit, what they are called to do, and they are pursuing an enlarged territory with a vengeance.

Gideon father Joash was a farmer, and Gideon was a hired hand on his father's farm. The highest expectations anyone had for Gideon was that he would one day take over his father's farm. There is certainly nothing wrong with that, but God had a more noble cause for this young man. When the plan of God was revealed to him Gideon threw down the altars of Baal and cut down the groves that provided fuel for the altars. When the rulers of the land heard what he had done they wanted to kill him but Gideon's father convinced them not to. Gideon took an army of 32,000 men and grew it to 300. He confronted the Midianites and the Amalekites with pitchers and lanterns and delivered Israel from the hand of oppression.

If God can use a farm hand to deliver a nation, he can use you to help accomplish his plan for the ages. If God can cause Mr. Pain to be blessed above his brothers he can take underachievers like you and I and turn us into overachievers!

Do you want to be a **benchwarmer** or a **boundary buster**? (Peter – walked where no one but Jesus has walked, because he was weary with being a benchwarmer and decided to be a boundary buster!)

VII. SEIZING NEW TERRITORY!

A. 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) ***“And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.”*** Depending on the Bible version you are reading the word “Territory” may also be translated “**Borders**” or “**Coasts**”.

In the context of the time this Scripture is being written the more land or holdings you had the more provision, security, and

influence you enjoyed. A person without any land was not called upon for advice; was not chosen for leadership positions; was only one meal away from a forced fast; had no security and very little chance for upward mobility!

Jesus becomes to us what **territory** was to Jabez. Without him we have no provision (Everything we have comes from the Lord); no security (In him we live, breathe, and have our being); whatever influence we think we have will be extremely small and short lived (We tend to self-destruct).

B. I want to talk to you about three specific territories of our lives that need to be enlarged:

- **Spiritual** territory – Prayer, life in the Word, and a personal relationship with the Lord!
- **Ministry** territory – Ministry happens when you use your influence to aid others in their pursuit of God or his will. If we really believe the thing that is going to count in eternity is what we have done for the Lord, our daily prayer will become ***“Lord enlarge my ministry territory”***. Are you doing what God has called you to do? Are you doing all God has called you to do? Are you doing the best you can with what you have been given?
- **Temporal** territory - John 10:10 (NKJV) ***“The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.”*** The word ***“Abundantly”*** as it is used in this Scripture means superior. I believe God wants to bless us in all areas of our lives. (Obed Edom)

C. I believe Jabez prayed for his territory to be enlarged for the following reasons;

- He could come to know God in a more **personal** and **intimate** way
- He could make **life** easier for his family

- He could make a greater mark for the God of Israel

Listen to this; 1 Chronicles 4:9 (NKJV) “***Now Jabez was more honorable than his brothers.***” What a miracle Jabez was more honorable than his brothers! He had a better family; he had more possessions; he had more property; he had more influence; he had more of everything than did his brothers! You don’t see any of their names in this passage do you?

The miracle of all miracles is that Jabez understood where all these blessings were derived from! (He was much like the terrapin on the stump!)

When you get your territory enlarged you had better always remember where it is coming from or you may be buying your ticket back to the place of your origination! (Be nice to people on your way up, you may meet them again; on your way back down!)

Psalms 121:1-8 (KJV) “***I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help. ²My help cometh from the LORD, which made heaven and earth. ³He will not suffer thy foot to be moved: he that keepeth thee will not slumber. ⁴Behold, he that keepeth Israel shall neither slumber nor sleep. ⁵The LORD is thy keeper: the LORD is thy shade upon thy right hand. ⁶The sun shall not smite thee by day, nor the moon by night. ⁷The LORD shall preserve thee from all evil: he shall preserve thy soul. ⁸The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this time forth, and even for evermore.***”

VIII. THE ULTIMATE TERRITORY!

A. Last week we talked about seizing new territory. We focused on three distinct territories; spiritual; ministry; and temporal. There is no question that these areas are of great importance to all of us but there is a sphere that stands head and shoulders above the rest: That sphere is the evangelization of the world.

In order to get a proper grasp on the subject of enlarging our territory to include the evangelization of the lost we must first gain an understanding of the Old and New Testaments, how they are related, and what significance they play in our lives today.

- The Bible is composed of two testaments, the Old and the new about two peoples, the Jews and Christians. Some people want to divide the two and say that the Old has no relevance to the New.
- The two Testaments have one overriding message, God is seeking a people who will worship and serve Him by bringing the message of salvation to the entire human race.
- The Old Testament is predicated on the premise of God's covenant with Abraham. Genesis 12:1-3 (NKJV) ***"Now the LORD had said to Abram: 'Get out of your country, from your family and from your father's house, to a land that I will show you. 2 I will make you a great nation; I will bless you and make your name great; and you shall be a blessing. 3 I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse him who curses you; and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.'"*** The covenant between God and Abraham is two-fold: (1) to give the Jewish people a piece of real estate that they could call their own; a place they could possess and be safe from their enemies. As you know, the Jewish nation has never quite attained all that God has desired for them. Certainly, this is not a failure on God's part, but a failure on the part of the Jewish nation to live up to the potential that God has placed within them. (Talk about the strife they have been involved in even to this day) After forty years of wandering around in the wilderness Pastor Moses speaks to the Israelites while in the land of Moab just prior to passing the leadership role to Joshua. Deuteronomy 1:8 (NKJV) ***"See, I have set the land before you; go in and possess***

the land which the LORD swore to your fathers—to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob—to give to them and their descendants after them.” See, it was never a question of whether they could; it was a question of whether they would. That is still the question today for them and for us! (2) The second and most important part of God’s missionary heart to reach all nations through His people, the Jews, and ultimately His Son, Jesus Christ. Galatians 3:8 (NKJV) *“And the Scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the gospel to Abraham beforehand, saying, ‘In you all the nations shall be blessed.’”*

- In the New Testament the focus shifts from reaching the world through the Jewish Nation to reaching the world through the church. According to the Scriptures this is to be done without regard to gender, race, nationality, or social standing. John 3:16-17 (NKJV) *“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life. 17 For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved.”* This may suggest that some of us need to enlarge our territory!
- Instead of possessing land, we are being told to go and make disciples! Matthew 28:19-20 *“Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, 20 “teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.”*

B. If the ultimate territory consists of being used to bring others into a personal relationship with Jesus Christ, how can I expand my territory?

- Pray for opportunities to expand your territory

- Anxiously anticipate the opportunities

These opportunities are what we will call **Jabez appointments**, they occur when you respond to divinely arranged encounters, and allow God to act through you. We are going to look at two such Jabez appointments in the Bible;

- Directed by an Angel, Philip traveled into the desert for a Jabez appointment with an Ethiopian government official. The official was traveling by chariot back to Africa. Acts 8:29-39 (NKJV) ***“Then the Spirit said to Philip, ‘Go near and overtake this chariot.’30 So Philip ran to him, and heard him reading the prophet Isaiah, and said, ‘Do you understand what you are reading?’31 And he said, ‘How can I, unless someone guides me?’ And he asked Philip to come up and sit with him.32 the place in the Scripture which he read was this: ‘He was led as a sheep to the slaughter; And as a lamb before its shearer is silent, So He opened not His mouth. 33 In His humiliation His justice was taken away, and who will declare His generation? For His life is taken from the earth.’ 34 So the eunuch answered Philip and said, ‘I ask you, of whom does the prophet say this, of himself or of some other man?’35 Then Philip opened his mouth, and beginning at this Scripture, preached Jesus to him.36 now as they went down the road, they came to some water. And the eunuch said, ‘See, here is water. What hinders me from being baptized?’ 37 Then Philip said, ‘If you believe with all your heart, you may.’ And he answered and said, ‘I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.’ 38 So he commanded the chariot to stand still. And both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water, and he baptized him.39 Now when they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord caught Philip away, so that the eunuch saw him no more; and he went on his way rejoicing.”*** Without this miraculously arranged appointment, the Ethiopian government

official, who had come to Jerusalem in search of God, would have returned home without hearing the Gospel.

- A Gentile soldier named Cornelius is hungry to know more about the things of God. With the help of an Angel, and a very alarming dream, God brought **Cornelius** and the Apostle **Peter** together. The results: A family came to faith in Christ, a believer expanded his boundaries and his understanding of God's love, and the church broke through some ancient and vicious boundaries of prejudice

C. Two things that create the **dynamics** of a Jabez appointment;

- God sets up the **appointment**
- The individual **recognizes** and **seizes** the opportunity

IX. HURDLES TO OVERCOME IN SEIZING NEW TERRITORY!

A. Last week we talked about three things:

- The meaning of territory
- Evangelism, the ultimate territory
- Witnessing opportunities, also known as Jabez appointments

A Jabez appointment is a **miracle**. It occurs when God moves supernaturally to arrange circumstances and bring people together in a way that stretches your ministry and expands your territory. (Jeremiah - "Go to the house of the potter...")

Miracles are not **magic** and do not always break or defy the laws of **nature**. Miracles do however require the intervention of God.

When Jesus calmed the storm no law of nature was broken. Only the timing of the end of the storm was changed. The storm was going to eventually end; no storm lasts forever, they only appear to last forever.

When Jesus provided the disciples with a huge catch of fish no law of nature was broken, but God supernaturally brought the fish and Peter's net together.

The miracle of a Jabez appointment occurs when;

- God arranges your day to **connect** you with the right person
- God gives you **words** to say when you are at a loss for **words**
- God provides **wisdom** when you know it was not your own
- God gives you **boldness** when you are afraid
- God brings to mind **Scriptures** related to the situation

B. All of us have established invisible **lines** within us, and have vowed not to cross those **lines**. While some lines are very good others keep us fenced in from receiving new territory and restrict us from being available for Jabez appointments. These **lines** include;

- **Borders**
- **Limits**
- **Comfort zones**

If you have allowed any of these things to restrict you from receiving new territory or being available for a Jabez appointment why do you suppose you have allowed those things to persist for such a long time? Because we have been duped into believing our life is better because of the lines. We have been taught to believe those lines are our friends! (Matt Burrow – Fear – He said it was his friend!)

C. I want to look at five things that keep us from **seizing** new territory, and how to cross the borders; exceed the limits; and go beyond the comfort zones.

- **TIMIDITY** – Some people are so afraid of new people and new situations that the only way they would even consider a Jabez appointment would be from the safety of their own home, and the comfort of their own couch. Proverbs 29:25 (NKJV) *“The fear of man brings a snare, But whoever trusts in the LORD shall be safe.”* Jeremiah 1:6-8 (NKJV) *“Then said I: ‘Ah, Lord GOD! Behold, I cannot speak, for I am a youth.’ 7 But the LORD said to me: ‘Do not say, I am a youth, for you shall go to all to whom I send you, and whatever I command you, you shall speak. 8 do not be afraid of their faces, for I am with you to deliver you,’” says the LORD.”* 2 Timothy 1:7 (NKJV) *“For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.”*
- LACK OF **GIFTEDNESS** – Have you ever met anyone who was extremely gifted but did not see themselves as gifted at all? This flows out of a lack of proper self-esteem and serves to neutralize the gifts God has placed in that individual. 1 Corinthians 1:26-29 (NKJV) *“For you see your calling, brethren, that not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble, are called.27 But God has chosen the foolish things of the world to put to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to put to shame the things which are mighty;28 and the base things of the world and the things which are despised God has chosen, and the things which are not, to bring to nothing the things that are,29 that no flesh should glory in His presence.”* God is not nearly as concerned about your ability as He is your availability! 2 Corinthians 4:7 (NKJV) *“But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellence of the power may be of God and not of us.”*
- FEAR OF **FAILURE** – Fear of failure can be paralyzing because it maximizes the impossible and minimizes the possible. Fear of failure causes a person to live their life

traveling in small circles, and totally ignoring the opportunity to broaden their horizons thus never realizing the opportunities God has ordained in their life. Psalm 18:28-36 (NKJV) ***“For You will light my lamp; The LORD my God will enlighten my darkness. 29 For by You I can run against a troop, by my God I can leap over a wall. 30 As for God, His way is perfect; the word of the LORD is proven; He is a shield to all who trust in Him. 31 For who is God, except the LORD? And who is a rock, except our God? 32 It is God who arms me with strength, and makes my way perfect. 33 He makes my feet like the feet of deer, and sets me on my high places. 34 He teaches my hands to make war, So that my arms can bend a bow of bronze. 35 You have also given me the shield of Your salvation; Your right hand has held me up, Your gentleness has made me great. 36 You enlarged my path under me, so my feet did not slip.”*** The fear of failure is rooted in pride; we don’t want anyone to see us fail. John Maxwell wrote the book “Failing Forward” in which he encourages his readers to turn their defeats into triumphs by using the mistakes to achieve excellence in the future. There are two things people will never forgive you for; failure and success.

- LOSS OF **CONTROL** – Whether we want to admit it or not most of us struggle with some control issues in our lives. We want to be in control and do not like being out of control. We worry about where God will send us; what He will ask us to do; how our life will change; where we will end up at. All of this is really a trust issue. Do we trust God or not? Romans 12:1 (NKJV) ***“I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service.”*** Psalm 56:3-4 (NKJV) ***“Whenever I am afraid, I will trust in You. 4 In God (I will praise His word), In God I have put my trust; I will not fear. What can flesh do to me?”*** Proverbs 3:5-6 (NKJV) ***“Trust in the LORD***

with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; 6 in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He shall direct your paths.” Psalm 37:3-7 (NKJV)
“Trust in the LORD, and do good; Dwell in the land, and feed on His faithfulness. 4 Delight yourself also in the LORD; and He shall give you the desires of your heart. 5 Commit your way to the LORD; Trust also in Him, and He shall bring it to pass. 6 He shall bring forth your righteousness as the light, and your justice as the noonday. 7 Rest in the LORD, and wait patiently for Him; Do not fret because of him who prospers in his way, Because of the man who brings wicked schemes to pass.”

- **BUSYNESS** – Most of us feel we are too overextended to be taking on any more responsibility. Though we live in a fast paced world and shoulder a lot of responsibility; our problem is normally not a problem of business but of busyness! Busyness is characterized by false responsibility that keeps us from the weightier matters of life. Isaiah 40:29-31 (NKJV) *“He gives power to the weak, And to those who have no might He increases strength. 30 even the youths shall faint and be weary, And the young men shall utterly fall, 31 But those who wait on the LORD Shall renew their strength;”* Matthew 11:28-30 (NKJV) *“Come to Me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.29 “Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.30 “For My yoke is easy and My burden is light.”*

We should consistently be praying for God to make us available for Jabez appointments; that we would overcome all borders, limits, and zones to seize the territory He has already given to us.

X. THE PRESENCE OF GOD!

A. Jabez moves beyond a request for a simple blessing to ask for the presence of God upon His life. I want us to look closely at the intent of his request. I believe the request of Jabez for the hand of God upon his life can be broken down into two parts:

- The Hand of God
- The Presence of God

In addition to these two things I want us to talk about Philosophies that keep us from the Presence of God.

The Hand of God – One of the foundational teachings of the Scripture is the desire of God to be involved in the affairs of man. Consider the following attempts by God to become involved in the affairs of His people;

- He created man for fellowship and communed with him on a daily basis - Genesis 3:8 (NKJV) ***“And they heard the sound of the LORD God walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and Adam and his wife hid themselves from the presence of the LORD God among the trees of the garden.”***
- When man sinned and was driven out of the garden, God immediately announced His plan for man’s redemption - Genesis 3:14-15 ***“So the LORD God said to the serpent: ‘Because you have done this, You are cursed more than all cattle, And more than every beast of the field; On your belly you shall go, And you shall eat dust All the days of your life. 15 And I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your seed and her Seed; He shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise His heel.’”*** The redemption of man was not just a fire insurance policy but an attempt to restore fellowship between the creator and His creation.
- Before the destruction of the flood God sent Noah to make an attempt at reconciliation.

- During the wilderness wandering God provided a **Mercy Seat**, a pillar of **cloud** by day and a pillar of **fire** by night.
- In Old Testament worship God provided a Holy of Holies in an attempt to **communicate** with fallen man.
- Think of all the messengers, Angels, Prophets, Prophetesses, and preachers that he sent throughout the **Old Testament**.
- The ultimate attempt at **reconciliation** can be found in John 3:16 (NKJV) “**For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.**”

Though the presence of God in your life is primarily intended for **fellowship**, it also provides the power and **resources** needed to do the will of God.

Jabez had a wonderful understanding of this when he prayed 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) “***And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.***”

Jabez knew that if the hand of God was upon him he would enjoy the fellowship of God; the favor of God; the presence of God; the resources of God; and the power of God.

My question tonight is:

How badly do we want His presence?

Are we willing to pay the price for His presence?

If we get His presence are we willing to receive His input?

Are we seeking Him for relationship purposes or for resources?

Remember, the proof of **desire** is **pursuit**!

B. The presence of God – 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) “*And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me...’*” Jabez was aware of the importance of the presence of Jehovah in his life. He knew that the presence of Jehovah was THE ingredient that would separate him from all the other common losers and underachievers!

When you think about seeking God’s hand you would probably be thinking in terms of seeking His hand for what is in it. When you seek His presence you are seeking for relationship, companionship and direction.

I believe Jabez also knew that he was capable of squandering the things he received from the hand of God if he was not living his life in the presence of God!

Seeking what is in God’s hand is not in and of itself a bad thing; we all need and want what is in His hand:

- Salvation
- Holy Spirit Baptism
- Healing
- Provision

Though all the things you can receive from the hand of God are wonderful, we must be seeking after God not just what he is capable of giving us. Matthew 6:33 (NKJV) “*But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things shall be added to you.*”

We have a tendency to reverse the order, seeking things all the while hoping they will make us righteous. (Lot - Ananias & Sapphira...)

If you want things, the proper way to get them is to acquire them while in pursuit of the life of God. If you acquire things in this manner they will be of minimal importance and your relationship with God will be of ultimate importance.

The following is a little spirituality test:

- Would you rather spend time with God or time with your friends?
- Are you more likely to read the Bible or some other book?
- Would you rather spend time with other Christians or do you prefer to hang around with the unconverted?
- Do you love spending time with His people or do you fail to take advantage of such opportunities? (Are you a clock watcher?)
- Are you passionately driven to a place of Kingdom service or do you shirk as much responsibility as possible?
- Are you inclined to witness when given opportunity or do you sidestep the issue?
- Are you a tipper or a tither?

If we seek the presence of God rather than temporal things what can we expect our lives to look like?

- We will be filled with the Spirit Acts 2
- We will have God's presence continually
- We will see and seize new opportunities for ministry

C. Philosophies that keep us from His presence – Though Jabez is asking for God's presence in his life he would have to overcome multiple obstacles in his pursuit of the presence of God:

- He had to make Jehovah a priority

- He had to overcome feelings of inferiority
- He had to overcome what others thought
- He had to relinquish control

Have you ever wondered why we don't have more of God's presence in our lives when there is obviously much more available to us?

If we are to acquire God's presence, we must do the following things:

- Make God and His will our priority
- Overcome inferiority and false humility
- Believe God wants to lead us
- Minimize the importance of pleasing the flesh and others
- Give total control of our lives over to God

Jabez no doubt understood the benefits of being led by Jehovah but the real question was; could he do what was necessary to have this presence? When he started getting blessed could he maintain his focus over the long haul?

If we are to know God in an intimate way we also must seek His presence, pay the price and maintain our focus over the long haul! (Rome was not built in a day!)

Song (O' Lord send the power just now)

XI. KEEP ME FROM EVIL

A. 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) *"And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, 'Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and*

enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.” The word “evil” as it is used here comes from the Hebrew word “ra” (rah) and means adversity, affliction, or calamity.

Jabez is praying God will keep his life from adversity, affliction, and calamity. Have you ever met anyone who was accident pronged? It just seems that when bad things happen they are always present. It is possible they are living under a curse – the curse.

Remember, from birth Jabez has been set up for failure. He has been programmed to set his goals low so as not to be disappointed and devastated by failure. Failure has become a catch phrase in Jabez’ life and family, so if he is not successful who will notice?

If you live in the skin of Jabez and it is truly your desire to change your fortunes you realize you are going to need a little divine intervention. Jabez was also aware he had to be careful of every decision because he was accident pronged when it came to decision making, it was almost as if he had a death wish.

He did not have a death wish his mother cursed him and he was attempting to live above the curse. This curse may not have any validity in the spirit realm but it certainly set him up psychologically for failure.

There are very few adversities more damaging or defeating than poverty. Poverty sets its victims up psychologically for an entire lifetime of bad choices that lead to devastating results.

If you have ever been closely connected to a person who grew up in abject poverty, as a rule, you will find the following things to be true:

- They suffer from an inferiority complex
- They hide in the shadows

- They do not pursue friendships outside their *economic* status
- Their choice of friends often keep them trapped in a *self-defeating* lifestyle
- They learn to expect the *worst*
- They become bad *stewards* not taking pride in the things they do have
- They wander through life somewhat aimlessly without any clear *objectives* or goals
- They often perpetuate another *generation* of underachievers
- They become trapped in a *vicious* cycle when they need to ride a *victory* cycle out of familiar surroundings
(History of Israel – Sin – Servitude – Repentance – Deliverance – Freedom – Sin...)

B. Jabez refused to be governed by the law of “*Normal Expectation*” he desired to use the life given to him by God to prove with a little divine intervention it is possible for anyone to ride a “*Victory* Cycle” out of any circumstance.

The government has made what I think to be a valiant attempt to raise the living standard and expectations of the poor in this country through welfare, food stamps, government subsidy's, raising the minimum wage, and many other programs. I am certainly not preaching against any of these things but the reason the programs have by-in-large failed is because the spiritual element has been totally ignored in our “Separation of Church and State” philosophy. (Church and state is only separate until there is a national crisis)

As we have discovered in previous lessons Jabez was cognizant of the fact, he would not succeed unless and until he found *divine* favor. (Favor isn't fair)

Just recently you have begun to hear about “Faith Based Initiatives”; this is an attempt by the Federal Government to deal God back into the hand of alleviating human suffering. The

ACLU has probably done more to destroy America than any other group on the face of the earth.

“Faith Based Initiatives” are proof that even pagans have come to the realization; the only way to build people is to place spiritual values and morality at the foundational level of all human help.

C. Jabez no doubt believed he could liberate his offspring and many others from a “Vicious Cycle” if he could first find a way out. You cannot offer others what you have not experienced.

The job of the church is to restore people. When you are in the business of restoring people you must be concerned with the following things;

- Helping them find their way spiritually
- Helping them find their way professionally
- Helping them find their way financially
- Helping them find their way relationally
- Helping them find their way emotionally

What are we here for? Are we here to become personally blessed? If so, that is perfectly fine as long as you intend to find a way to bless others once you become blessed. If you get blessed then refuse to bless others your blessing and happiness will be short lived because God is not in a habit of digging ponds he creates rivers.

XII. THAT I MIGHT NOT CAUSE PAIN

A. 1 Chronicles 4:10 (NKJV) “*And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, ‘Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!’ So God granted him what he requested.*” I would like to begin this evening by reminding you of the definition of the word "evil" - It comes from the Hebrew word “ra” (rah) and means adversity, affliction, or calamity. The word "pain" on the other hand means:

- Sensation of hurting caused by injury, disease, etc., transmitted by the nervous system
- The distress or suffering caused by anxiety, grief, disappointment, etc.

Where there is pain there is always a problem causing the pain.

We are going to take a closer look at the definition of "pain" in an effort to discover the truth Jabez is attempting to illuminate. In our examination we are going to attempt to identify some problem areas in our own life.

B. "Pain" - Sensation of hurting caused by injury, disease, etc., transmitted by the nervous system. We are going to look at this in a very literal sense.

If I hit my finger with a hammer every available warning system in my body springs into action; my body notifies my nervous system something has gone terribly wrong; my nervous system notifies my brain that an injury has occurred and pain has invaded my body; my brain notifies my defense system and my opposite hand grabs the finger; my whole body springs into action and prepares to do whatever is necessary to initiate measures of damage control.

At this point I have a decision to make:

- Employ all available damage control measures
- Take a pain killer and go to bed

If I employ all measures of damage control all my resources become available to eliminate the pain and begin the healing process. (Family members & friends; bank accounts, savings accounts & holdings; medical insurance etc)

If I take a pain killer and go to bed I must be aware when the influence of the drugs wear off I will be back to hurting because the source of the pain has not really been dealt with.

Many people live artificially intoxicated lives because they have suffered injury; they have buried, ignored, and denied their pain hoping it will miraculously disappear.

You can place a band-aid on a cancer but the band-aid will only cover the manifested area for a short period of time and will not keep the disease from spreading. If the disease is not properly dealt with it has the potential of negatively affecting the entire body and ultimately causing death.

Miracles occur when the source of pain has been identified and dealt with. A surgery can be painful but the potential of good health is much greater after the surgery than before.

Once the source has been dealt with and healing occurs the pain will disappear and there will be no more need for medication or intoxication.

C. The most common source of "pain" is of an emotional nature rather than a physical nature:

- The loss of a family member or friend
- An offense by a friend or relative
- An unwelcome intrusion

It is my opinion more damage is being done, more pain is being suffered, more dreams are being relinquished, and more lives are being wrecked by these things than by things of a physical nature.

I can go to a doctor and get some anti-depressants but as soon as the influence of the drugs wears off I am back to dealing with my loss and wounded spirit.

I want us to look at five ways the enemy gains access to our lives:

- Trespass
- Intrusion
- Un-forgiveness

- Generational curses
- Legal ground

Many people go through life attempting to keep themselves intoxicated enough to make the pain bearable. Because they are intoxicated they often withdraw or become obnoxious; make bad decisions and poor choices. These things serve to perpetuate a downward spiral that ultimately ends in a wasted life. (Song my wife sang to me on our 20th anniversary - "wasted years")

Jabez had a grasp on these truths when he prayed against the effects of "pain" in his life. He did not want to spend ten, twenty, thirty, forty, fifty years medicating his pain and licking his wounds he wanted to rise above his pain and live a full and blessed life.

CONCLUSION:

If the aforementioned facts are not reason enough to do what is necessary to rise above your pain here is another reason; hurt people, hurt people.

If you fail to properly deal with your pain you will eventually hurt those you love the most.

If you truly desire to deal with your pain let me give you a checklist for taking proper action:

- Ask God to forgive you - Only God can forgive sin
- Ask others to forgive you - Leave your gift at the altar - Matthew 5:23-24 *"Therefore if you bring your gift to the altar, and there remember that your brother has something against you, ²⁴ leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift."*
- Confess to others if necessary - James 5:16 *"Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The effective, fervent prayer of a righteous man avails much."* - Note: This

confession is not in the sense of forgiveness but accountability.

- Refuse to **reclaim** the pain - When I am tempted to reclaim pain I always start praying the blessing of God over the individual

XIII. SO GOD GRANTED HIM WHAT HE REQUESTED!

1 Chronicles 4:9-10 (NKJV) *"Now Jabez was more honorable than his brothers, and his mother called his name Jabez, saying, 'Because I bore him in pain.'¹⁰ And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, 'Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!' So God granted him what he requested."*

I suppose an age old question would be, "why do some people get their prayers answered while others do not?" Most people assume it has more to do with the luck of the draw than anything else.

While answers to prayers sometimes feel more like a lottery than anything else, it is really more scientific than that. After careful study of the Word of God I believe there is an art to getting your prayers answered.

First of all let me just remind you that God always answers prayer; sometimes He say's yes; sometimes He say's no; sometimes He say's not now; but He always answers prayer.

I am convinced the key to getting what we believe we need is not necessarily wrapped up in God answering a prayer, but in our being in a position to hear the answer. (Daniel - 21 day's - the prayer was answered the first day but he did not get the answer for 21 day's)

In an attempt to discover the key to getting our prayers answered I want us to take a look at the text we have been studying for several months. Jabez asked for **five** tings:

- **Bless** me indeed

- **Enlarge** my territory
- May your **hand** be upon me
- Keep me from **evil**
- Help me not to cause **pain**

The miraculous element of the life of Jabez is found in the latter part of verse ten, ***"So God granted him what he requested."*** Sounds easy enough, does it not? It is not quite as easy to live as it is to read, or is it?

I want us to consider **two** New Testament scriptures along with the prayer of Jabez:

John 15:7 (NKJV) ***"If you abide in Me, and My words abide in you, you will ask what you desire, and it shall be done for you."***

Luke 18:1-8 (NKJV) ***"Then He spoke a parable to them, that men always ought to pray and not lose heart, 2 saying: 'There was in a certain city a judge who did not fear God nor regard man.3 'Now there was a widow in that city; and she came to him, saying, 'Get justice for me from my adversary.'4 'And he would not for a while; but afterward he said within himself, 'Though I do not fear God nor regard man,5 'yet because this widow troubles me I will avenge her, lest by her continual coming she weary me.' 6 Then the Lord said, 'Hear what the unjust judge said.7 'And shall God not avenge His own elect who cry out day and night to Him, though He bears long with them?8 'I tell you that He will avenge them speedily. Nevertheless, when the Son of Man comes, will He really find faith on the earth?'"***

There are **three** things I want to point out from these three scriptures:

A. The first step to receiving satisfactory answers to our prayers is to make sure our prayers are in **agreement** with the Word of God. Before praying a prayer we should always ask "Does this

violate the Word of God"? The second question should be, "Is this in agreement with the Word of God"?

In the parable of the persistent widow, agreement with God's Word can be seen in verse three: Luke 18:3 (NKJV) *"Now there was a widow in that city; and she came to him, saying, 'Get justice for me from my adversary.'"* This lines up with Psalm 140:12 (NKJV) *"I know that the LORD will maintain The cause of the afflicted, And justice for the poor."*

Our prayers should not only line up with the written Word of God but also with the revealed Word of God. We should always test the revealed Word of God against the written Word of God. The revealed Word of God will always agree with the written Word of God. If the revealed Word of God does not agree totally with the written Word of God then you have failed to properly understand and interpret the revealed Word of God.

Jesus prayed according to the written and revealed Word of God Luke 22:42 (NKJV) *"Father, if it is Your will, take this cup away from Me; nevertheless not My will, but Yours, be done."*

Jesus instructed us to pray according to the written and revealed Word of God. Matthew 6:9-10 (NKJV) *"In this manner, therefore, pray: Our Father in heaven, Hallowed be Your name. 10 Your kingdom come. Your will be done On earth as it is in heaven."*

Some people always end their prayers in the following way, "If it be thy will Lord". Is it proper to pray in this way? The answer is yes and no! Yes, if you are praying about something you truly do not know what the will of God is. In such cases you should attempt to discover His will before you pray. (Research the scripture)

No, if you know your prayer is in line with His written and revealed will. Do not pray in this way if you know for sure what His will is before you pray. To pray in this way when you know His will is to allow doubt as to whether or not God is willing to do what He has already said He would do.

Once you know your prayers are in line with His written and revealed will you can stand on John 15:7 (NKJV) ***"If you abide in Me, and My words abide in you, you will ask what you desire, and it shall be done for you."***

In studying the life of Jabez I have come to believe that he not only wanted a better way of life but believed God's will for he and his family was upward mobility. John 10:10 (NKJV) ***"The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly."***

B. Step two is to be consistent and persistent. This is a consistent life and persistent prayer. In the parable of the widow, she showed up every day with the same request persisting in her pursuit of justice.

This godless judge vindicated the persistent widow because of her continual requests. This judge was godless but made a decision in her favor simply on the basis of her consistency and persistence.

God does not make decisions based on how many times you pray a prayer but this parable makes it clear that we are not to make a habit of praying once and forgetting it. The habit of praying repeatedly until the answer is revealed is not for the benefit of the judge but to keep the importance of the issue before us, which tends to aid in the process of the prioritization of the issues of life.

I know there is a great debate on how many times we should pray the same prayer. Some say pray once and forget it; this is the "leave it there" philosophy. (Leave them there, leave them there, take your burdens to the Lord and leave them there)

Others say continue praying until you are in possession of the answer; this is the "sight, not faith" philosophy. Allow me to throw some things out for your consideration;

- Remember, all prayers get answered the first time - The delay is in our receiving of the answer

- We receive the evidence of the answer to some prayers the first time we pray
- We receive the answer to some prayers and the proof of the answer is revealed at a later date
- The answer and proof of the answer to some prayers is simultaneous

Jesus spoke of this persistence and consistency in John 15:7 (NKJV) *"If you abide in Me, and My words abide in you, you will ask what you desire, and it shall be done for you."*

Do you think Jabez received his blessing by praying one time and hoping for the best? Jabez was not willing to risk the future of his life on spinning the wheel of fortune. He consistently and persistently pursued a better way of life.

Just how important is a brighter future for you and your offspring? Are you willing to take your chances on one prayer; or are you willing to labor in prayer until you have the assurance in your spirit that the lord has heard and answered prayer?

Notice how this parable begins, Luke 18:1 *"Then He spoke a parable to them, that men always ought to pray and not lose heart."*

C. Step three is to claim the answer by faith!

Step three will be almost impossible without step one and two! (Determining the will of God, being persistent in prayer and consistent in life)

The lack of attention to step one and two is what makes prayer seem so much like a lottery. When step one and two have been employed and step three is enjoined the answer to prayer becomes rather predictable.

Claiming a thing by faith requires knowing it is the will of God. That is the reason it is so difficult to receive an answer when you tack "if it be thy will Lord" on to the end of each prayer.

Luke 18:8 (NKJV) ***"I tell you that He will avenge them speedily. Nevertheless, when the Son of Man comes, will He really find faith on the earth?"***

James 1:2-8 (KJV) ***"My brethren, count it all joy when ye fall into divers temptations; 3 Knowing this, that the trying of your faith worketh patience. 4 But let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect and entire, wanting nothing. 5 If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him. 6 But let him ask in faith, nothing wavering. For he that wavereth is like a wave of the sea driven with the wind and tossed. 7 For let not that man think that he shall receive any thing of the Lord. 8 A double minded man is unstable in all his ways."***

Hebrews 10:35-36 (NKJV) ***"Therefore do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward. 36 For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise."***

When Jabez prayed concerning he and his offspring's upward mobility I believe he was convinced beyond doubt he would receive his answer from the Lord. This was not just a shot in the dark, it was zooming in on the target; centering the crosshairs on the bulls-eye! The prayer of Jabez was a laser guided missile against the strongholds the enemy planned to use against him!

When Jabez was calling on God he had his mind made up to overcome the enemy called ***average***! He was determined for his spiritual life to take him to a much higher level than what he was expected to attain; to socialize above the friends the enemy had assigned to him; to live beyond the means his mother expected of him!

When he was praying he expected to receive what he was asking for!

CONCLUSION: In conclusion I want to list for you some reasons people do not get their prayers answered:

- Failure to ask equals failure in receiving
- Failure to pray specifically
- Allowance for secret sin
- Bitterness and resentment
- Selfishness
- Failure to pray according to the will of God
- Failure to persist in pursuit of answers
- Lack of faith